

etch

the place the algorithm
can't see



Feature Specification - 12 Features - 3 Phases

• A journaling sanctuary for Gen Z
• Not an archive. Not a tool. A sanctuary.

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build order

Phase 1 (MVP): Threshold - Canvas - Vibe Slider - Wax Seal - Local Pulse

Phase 2 (Hooks): Internal Weather - Echo - Anti-Journal Prompts - Burn Folder - Redact

Phase 3 (Virality): Color Cloud - End of Month Aura

killed (not building)

X Ghost Mode -- over-engineered

X PDF book export -- millennial legacy feature

X 'On This Day' nostalgia -- nostalgia is millennial, Gen Z journals for today

X Streak tracking -- toxic guilt, anti-sanctuary

X Gratitude prompts -- toxic positivity, boomer energy

X Social sharing of entries -- defeats the entire purpose

X AI-powered insights -- feels corporate, 'your AI wellness coach' is what Gen Z hates

The Threshold

Hold to enter. A ritual, not a login.

WHAT IT IS

When you open Etch, you see a dark screen with a subtle prompt. You hold your thumb on the screen for about 1.5 seconds. The screen responds with haptic feedback and transitions into the sanctuary.

WHY IT EXISTS

Gen Z needs a psychological boundary between the noise (TikTok, messages, notifications) and the sanctuary. A tap is too casual -- you can tap through anything on autopilot. Holding requires intention. It's a ritual of entry, like taking off your shoes before entering a temple.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

Full-screen SwiftUI view with a dark background.
LongPressGesture(minimumDuration: 1.5). UIImpactFeedbackGenerator -- light haptic on start, heavy on completion. Transition: screen dissolves into the Canvas (opacity + scale animation). Face ID/passcode happens seamlessly during the hold if enabled.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT a loading screen (the app is ready instantly -- the hold is deliberate friction). NOT a login (no accounts). NOT skippable (the hold IS the feature).

The Canvas

Tap anywhere to write. No format. No pressure.

WHAT IT IS

A free-form writing surface. When you enter the sanctuary, you see a blank canvas. Tap anywhere to place a text cursor and start writing. No 'New Entry' button. No title field. No 'Dear Diary.' Just space.

WHY IT EXISTS

Gen Z journaling is modular and raw -- brain dumps, vibe checks, three lines about a feeling. Traditional journal apps force structure: title, date, body paragraph. That structure is a millennial frame. Gen Z needs a surface that accepts whatever they give it -- a sentence, a word, a paragraph, nothing.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

SwiftUI ZStack with vibe-colored background. TextEditor positioned at tap location. Multiple text blocks can coexist (positioned freely). Entry saved as .md file with content + metadata (vibe, date). Auto-save on backgrounding or 3s inactivity.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT a lined notebook (no lines, no margins). NOT a blank canvas with a toolbar (no formatting buttons). NOT a word processor (no font picker, no tables). This is for feelings, not documents.

The Vibe Slider

Set emotional temperature before you write a single word.

WHAT IT IS

A horizontal slider with four positions: Chaotic, Static, Melancholy, Glowing. The slider changes the ambient color of the canvas as you move it. Chaotic = deep red, Static = steel gray, Melancholy = muted purple, Glowing = warm amber.

WHY IT EXISTS

Gen Z communicates mood through aesthetics, not words. 'How are you?' is an impossible question at 2am. But sliding to 'Chaotic' and watching the canvas turn deep red -- that's an answer. The vibe slider lets you set the emotional atmosphere before you write a single word. If you can't articulate it, you can at least color it.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

SwiftUI Slider mapped to 4 discrete positions. Each position has a color gradient. Canvas background animates to the selected gradient. Vibe stored in entry frontmatter: vibe: chaotic. Haptic tick on each position change.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT emoji selection (emoji are performative, vibe is atmospheric). NOT a 1-10 mood scale (numbers imply measurement, vibes imply feeling). NOT optional metadata that gets hidden (the vibe IS the canvas).

The Wax Seal

Saving feels like closure. Not a database write.

WHAT IT IS

When you finish an entry and it saves, a wax seal animation closes over it. A circle of warm color pools, solidifies, and stamps shut with a haptic click. The entry is sealed.

WHY IT EXISTS

Saving in most apps feels like nothing -- a spinner, a checkmark, a 'Saved!' toast. That's a database operation, not an emotional act. Gen Z needs the act of saving to feel like closure. You poured something out. Now it's sealed. It's done. You can let it go.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

SwiftUI overlay animation on save. Pool phase (0.5s): amber circle expands, opacity 0 to 0.7. Solidify (0.5s): edges sharpen, color deepens. Stamp (0.3s): scale bounce + heavy haptic. Fade (0.7s): returns to entry list. Total ~2s. Tap-to-dismiss after stamp.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT a loading indicator (save is instant, animation is emotional closure). NOT a confirmation dialog (no 'Are you sure?'). NOT a lock (entry can be reopened and edited -- the seal is symbolic).

The Local Pulse

A green heartbeat. Your entries never leave this device.

WHAT IT IS

A small, steady green heartbeat indicator visible in a corner of the canvas. It pulses softly -- a visual reminder that entries never leave the device. No server. No cloud. No company watching.

WHY IT EXISTS

Gen Z has been surveilled their entire lives. Every app tracks them. Every platform monetizes their data. The Local Pulse is a constant, quiet reassurance: this space is different. No one is watching. Your thoughts are yours. It's not a feature you use -- it's a feeling you trust.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

Small SwiftUI circle (8pt) with green color (#00C853). Pulsing animation: scale 1.0 to 1.3, opacity 0.6 to 1.0, 2-second cycle, repeatForever. Positioned in a non-intrusive corner. Tooltip on tap: 'Your entries never leave this device.' Can be hidden in settings.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT a sync status indicator (there is no sync to show). NOT a notification badge (doesn't count anything). NOT a logo or branding element (it's a reassurance signal).

Internal Weather

Can't name your feeling? Paint it.

WHAT IT IS

An alternative to the Vibe Slider for when you can't even name what you're feeling. You paint your mood with touch. Drag your finger across the screen and colors bloom where you touch -- stormy grays, anxious reds, calm blues, numb whites. Haptic feedback varies with the intensity of your stroke.

WHY IT EXISTS

Sometimes words fail and even the 4-option Vibe Slider is too precise. Internal Weather is pre-verbal mood expression. It's the journaling equivalent of screaming into a pillow. You feel something intense and inarticulate, and you paint it out of your body and onto the screen. The haptics ground you in your body (somatic grounding technique from therapy).

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

SwiftUI canvas with DragGesture touch tracking. Particle system or blob rendering at touch points -- color depends on pressure/speed. UIImpactFeedbackGenerator with intensity mapped to touch force. Colors: slow/gentle = cool blues, fast/aggressive = reds, slow/heavy = dark purples, light/scattered = whites. Result saved as image alongside the .md entry.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT a drawing tool (no brushes, no colors palette, no undo). NOT saved as a polished image (it's a snapshot of a feeling, not an artwork). NOT shared or shareable (pure private catharsis).

The Echo

One whisper from the past. Not nostalgia -- resonance.

WHAT IT IS

Once a day, when you enter the sanctuary, one past entry surfaces. Not 'On This Day 2 years ago' (that's nostalgia). Instead, The Echo finds a past entry whose vibe resonates with your current state. It shows one line from it -- a whisper, not a wall of text.

WHY IT EXISTS

Gen Z journals to survive today, not to remember yesterday. But sometimes a past entry connects to the present in a way that helps: 'I felt this before and I'm still here.' That's not nostalgia -- that's resonance. The Echo surfaces one connection, once a day, and then disappears. It doesn't drown you in your past.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

On app open (once per day max), query past entries. Match by vibe similarity (same vibe slider position) or by text keyword overlap. Display one sentence from the matched entry. User can tap to read full entry or swipe to dismiss. No more echoes until tomorrow. Can be disabled in settings.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT 'On This Day' (not date-based, vibe/resonance-based). NOT a feed of old entries (one entry, one whisper, once a day). NOT nostalgia (framing is 'this still matters,' not 'remember when?'). NOT a streak or habit mechanic.

Anti-Journal Prompts

Shadow work questions. Off by default. No gratitude lists.

WHAT IT IS

Optional writing prompts that appear only if you tap a small icon on the Canvas. The prompts are shadow work questions -- real, uncomfortable, honest. Not '3 things you're grateful for.' Things like: 'What did you pretend not to feel today?' or 'Who did you perform for today, and why?'

WHY IT EXISTS

Gen Z is deep into shadow work (#ShadowWork: 2 billion TikTok views). They want to go deeper than surface-level journaling. But they hate boomer gratitude prompts and corporate wellness language. Anti-Journal Prompts give them real questions -- the kind a therapist would ask, not an HR department. Off by default. You have to seek them out.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

Small icon on the Canvas edge. Tap reveals a random prompt from a curated local JSON list (~50 prompts at launch). Categories: shadow work, anxiety processing, identity, relationships, existential. Prompt appears as faint text overlay. No streak tracking. No gamification. Settings: customize categories, disable entirely.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT gratitude prompts (never). NOT forced (no popups, no notifications). NOT AI-generated (all human-written and curated). NOT daily (no 'prompt of the day' -- you seek them when you need them).

The Burn Folder

Entries that self-delete in 24 hours. Catharsis without permanence.

WHAT IT IS

A separate space in the app for entries that self-delete after 24 hours. You write something raw -- anger, jealousy, shame, a text you'll never send -- and instead of sealing it, you burn it. The entry exists for 24 hours (you can re-read it during that time), then it's permanently deleted. No trace.

WHY IT EXISTS

Some thoughts need to be expressed but not kept. Therapy calls this 'containment' -- you put the feeling somewhere safe, then let it go. Traditional journal apps keep everything forever, which means every angry rant, every shameful thought, every 2am spiral lives permanently in your archive. The Burn Folder is for catharsis without permanence. You said it. It's out of your body. Now it burns.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

Separate /burn/ directory in workspace. Entries have `burn: true` and `burn_ttl` in frontmatter. Visible countdown on each burn entry. At TTL expiry, `FileManager.removeItem` -- permanently deleted. During 24h, user can re-read, add to, or manually burn (immediate delete with fire animation). Burn entries excluded from search, Echo, and Color Cloud.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT a draft folder (drafts are things you'll finish -- burn entries are things you'll never need again). NOT recoverable (no trash bin, no undo -- burn means burn). NOT a feature for everyone (some users will never use it, and that's fine).

The Redact Tool

Permanently black out your own words. No undo.

WHAT IT IS

A tool within the entry editor that lets you permanently black out your own words. Select text, tap 'Redact,' and the text is replaced with a solid black bar. Permanently. The original text is gone from the file. You can't un-redact it.

WHY IT EXISTS

Sometimes you need to write something to process it, but you don't want those words to exist in your journal forever. The act of writing was the therapy -- the words don't need to survive it. Redacting is different from deleting the whole entry (you might want to keep the context but destroy the specific words). It's also different from the Burn Folder (you're keeping the entry, just killing part of it). Redact is surgical destruction.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

Text selection in editor -> 'Redact' in context menu. Selected text replaced with full block characters in the .md file. Original text NOT stored anywhere -- no metadata, no hidden backup. Visual: black bar rendered over text position. Heavy haptic on redact. Minimal confirmation: 'Redact permanently?' with no undo option after.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT edit/undo (redact is permanent, there is no un-redact). NOT strikethrough (strikethrough shows what was there, redact destroys it). NOT a security feature (it's an emotional release feature -- the point is the act of destroying the words).

The Color Cloud

Your month in color. No words. No entries. Just vibes.

WHAT IT IS

At the end of each month, Etch generates an abstract color field -- a visual representation of your month's vibes. Each entry's Vibe Slider position and Internal Weather data contribute colors. The result is a unique, abstract artwork: your emotional month as a color cloud. No text, no entries, no private data -- just colors.

WHY IT EXISTS

Gen Z shares aesthetics, not diaries. They won't post their journal entries on TikTok, but they will post a beautiful abstract color field that represents 'my October.' The Color Cloud is inherently shareable but inherently private -- it contains zero personal content. It's a vibe, not a confession. This is the virality engine.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

Aggregate all entries from the past month. Map vibe values to colors (Chaotic = red, Static = gray-blue, Melancholy = purple, Glowing = amber). Map Internal Weather data to texture/intensity. Render as abstract gradient/particle field using SwiftUI or Metal. Each day = one segment (31 max). User can view, save to photos, or share.

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT a mood chart or graph (no axes, no labels, no data viz -- it's art). NOT a summary of what you wrote (no text excerpts, no word clouds). NOT a personality test result (no 'You are 67% melancholic!' -- it's a color field).

End of Month Aura

5 seconds. No words. TikTok-ready.

WHAT IT IS

A 5-second animated video of your month's emotional journey. The Color Cloud, but animated -- colors shifting, blending, pulsing over 5 seconds. Set to ambient sound (or silent). Designed specifically for TikTok/Reels sharing. No text, no entries, no private data.

WHY IT EXISTS

The Color Cloud is a static image. The Aura is a video. TikTok rewards video. A 5-second abstract animation of 'my October vibes' is exactly the kind of content Gen Z shares -- aesthetic, emotional, mysterious, zero personal risk. The Aura is the single most important virality feature in the app.

HOW IT WORKS (TECH)

Reuse Color Cloud data but animate it: colors shift over time, particles drift. Render to 5-second video using AVAssetWriter + CADisplayLink or Metal. 1080x1920 (vertical, TikTok format). 30fps, 150 frames. Optional ambient audio. Export to Photos, share via share sheet. Subtle 'etch' watermark (can be disabled).

WHAT IT IS NOT

NOT a slideshow of entries (no text, no dates, no content). NOT a music video (no song integration -- ambient or silent). NOT a data visualization (it's a vibe, an aura, not a report).

summary

#	Feature	Tagline	Phase	Build
01	The Threshold	Hold to enter. A ritual.	MVP	Wk 1-4
02	The Canvas	Tap anywhere to write.	MVP	Wk 1-4
03	The Vibe Slider	Set emotional temperature.	MVP	Wk 1-4
04	The Wax Seal	Saving as closure.	MVP	Wk 1-4
05	The Local Pulse	Your entries never leave.	MVP	Wk 1-4
06	Internal Weather	Paint your mood.	HOOKS	Wk 5-8
07	The Echo	Resonance, not nostalgia.	HOOKS	Wk 5-8
08	Anti-Journal Prompts	Shadow work questions.	HOOKS	Wk 5-8
09	The Burn Folder	Self-delete in 24 hours.	HOOKS	Wk 5-8
10	The Redact Tool	Black out your words.	HOOKS	Wk 5-8
11	The Color Cloud	Your month in color.	VIRALITY	Wk 9-12
12	End of Month Aura	5-second shareable video.	VIRALITY	Wk 9-12

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\$24.99 one-time - no subscription - no tracking - no streaks - no gratitude prompts